



Space debris

The remains of the Long March 5B rocket is descending uncontrollably from its orbit.
<https://digit.in/aug22-46>

Your next laptop

Agent001 makes a simple list for folks looking to buy a new laptop

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very couple of months, I start getting a lot of queries from folks about their next

laptop purchase. Over the years, the needs of users have grown complex and the budgets have grown to match. The pandemic saw a lot more people purchasing new laptops for themselves, their kids and their folks across a wider price bracket ranging from cheap Chromebooks for students, to expensive content creating machines for budding YouTubers and of course, for work. I'm distilling all those recommendations down to a simple list of priorities for you to consider when you're out in the market looking for your next laptop.

Performance matters. The baseline that you should be looking for is either an AMD Ryzen 5 or Intel Core i5 processor from the current gen or previous gen. Gone are the days when core counts did not matter beyond four cores. The applications of today are increasingly utilising more of the cores made available to it. And the operating systems have also evolved to split workloads across more threads. Processors should be coupled with a decent amount of RAM. Never go below 8 GB of RAM. In fact, I'd say go for 16 GB in a dual-channel configuration. Manufacturers tend to

only offer a single-channel configuration in the budget segments but you will find a few good SKUs with dual-channel RAM configuration in all budgets. Why am I insisting on dual-channel memory? Because you tend to lose out approximately 11-17 per cent of performance without it. And just any RAM isn't going to cut it. Memory sticks have another parameter called 'Ranks' and having a single-rank RAM works better than a dual-rank RAM. The performance difference is around 2-3 per cent at the clock speeds that most laptops ship with. How can you tell the channel and rank of the memory configuration? If you can see the sticker, then it will

either read 1R or 2R. That tells you the rank. And if you have two sticks of RAM, then you're most probably running a dual-channel configuration. The most certain way is to run a third-party software such as CPU-Z which will highlight all of the above information clearly.

The operating system is also very important. Windows is the most popular operating system and most software that we need to use on a day-to-day basis is made for

Windows. Linux based machines can run additional software to make Windows apps run on Linux but there's no guarantee that they'll all run. macOS is easy to use only if you have an Apple ecosystem around you. Apple devices are notorious for making it difficult to interoperate with other ecosystems.



Graphics cards are strictly optional. The integrated graphics capabilities on processors are more than capable of running most applications with ease. Only if you need to run content creation apps or wish to play video games, should you opt for a powerful discrete graphics card. College-going kids might need laptops with discrete GPUs if they have classes that teach powerful CAD/CAM software. For everything else, the integrated graphics does great.